

THE BUYER'S CHECKLIST

Buying in the Riviera Maya

A 10-step guide for U.S. and Canadian buyers, from first idea to closing day.

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The 10 steps

Part one: deciding and searching

1 Decide your purpose

Vacation home, rental income, retirement, or a mix? Your purpose shapes the area, the type of unit and the budget.

2 Set your total budget

Plan for closing costs of about 5–8% on top of the price, plus furnishing and first-year costs.

3 Line up payment

Options include cash, a developer payment plan, borrowing against a home you own, or a Mexican mortgage (expect a bigger down payment and higher rates).

4 Choose your area

Visit more than once and in different seasons. Check sargassum and noise levels by season.

5 Tour with a checklist

Look for water stains, wide or stair-step cracks, drainage problems and the condition of shared areas.

The 10 steps

Part two: buying and closing

6

Make an offer and sign a purchase agreement

The agreement includes a deposit. Have an attorney review it before you sign.

7

Do your due diligence

Use a notary and your own independent attorney. Verify title, liens, unpaid taxes, permits and the developer's track record.

8

Set up the fideicomiso

In the coastal restricted zone, foreigners hold title through a bank trust. It runs 50 years, is renewable, and lets you use, rent, sell and leave the property to your heirs.

9

Close at the notary

Signing and registration happen at the notary. A resale typically takes about 4–8 weeks.

10

After closing

Set up utilities, HOA, a property manager and insurance. Check the HOA's rental rules. Work with a tax advisor in both countries.

Red flags to watch for

- 🚩 Pressure to pay a deposit before you have seen the title or the contract.
- 🚩 The seller won't let your attorney review the documents.
- 🚩 Wire instructions sent by email that differ from the notary's, or change at the last minute.
- 🚩 A price far below similar units.
- 🚩 No clear proof of ownership, or unpaid taxes and HOA fees.
- 🚩 A new development with no permits, no track record, or repeated delays.
- 🚩 An HOA with no reserve fund or financial statements.
- 🚩 Anyone who guarantees rental income or appreciation.

Questions to ask

About the property

- Who is the legal owner, and can I see the title?
- Are property taxes (predial) and HOA fees current?
- What permits and approvals does it have?
- Has it had water, structural or flooding problems?
- What is included in the sale?

About the deal

- What is the total cost including closing costs?
- How much is the deposit, and who holds it?
- What are the payment terms and deadlines?
- Can my attorney review every document before I sign?

About the building and area

- What are the monthly HOA fees and what do they cover?
- Are short-term rentals allowed?
- Is there a reserve fund, and can I see recent financials?

Key terms

Fideicomiso	A bank trust that holds title for foreign buyers in the restricted zone. 50 years, renewable.
Notario público	A government-appointed legal officer who verifies the title, calculates taxes and formalizes the sale.
Escritura	The public deed of sale, signed at the notary and registered.
Predial	The annual municipal property tax.
Cuota de mantenimiento	The monthly HOA or maintenance fee.
Gravamen	A lien or encumbrance on a property.
Restricted zone	The area within about 50 km of the coast, where foreigners buy through a fideicomiso.

Ready for a next step?

Book a free call and we'll talk through your plans.

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